



THE ANCIENT lake last made an appearance in 2023-24, above. This year's lake is much smaller, locals say.

DEATH VALLEY LAKE IS BACK

Ancient body of water reemerges after record November rainfall. It won't last long.

By SUMMER LIN

Between 128,000 and 186,000 years ago, when ice covered the Sierra Nevada, a lake 100 miles long and 600 feet deep sat in eastern California in what is now the Mojave Desert.

As the climate warmed and the ice retreated, the lake dried up, leaving a white salt pan in its place.

But a November of record rainfall has brought the ancient lake, known as Lake Manly, back to life. Now Death Valley, one of the hottest places on Earth and the lowest point in North America, has a desert lake framed by snow-capped mountains.

As far as lakes go, this one is pretty small and is likely to disappear soon.

But it's a marvel to people who live in or visit Death Valley, and a reminder of the extreme weather that has been hitting the area more than 200 feet below sea level.

Climate change has been a growing concern. A few years ago, when temperatures approached the 130-degree mark, "heat tourists" flocked to the desert. Officials have expressed concern about how hotter conditions can affect the plants, birds and wildlife.

Then, there is the rain.

From September to November, the park received 2.41 inches of rain, with 176 inches of that total coming in November alone, the Park Service said. The previous wettest November on record was 170 inches, in 1923.

The lake last made an appearance in 2023 after Hurricane Hilary, which degraded to a post-tropical low before reaching Southern California, dumped 2.2 inches of rain on the park and filled the basin.

Water levels receded until February 2024, when an atmospheric river dumped an additional 1.5 inches of rain onto the lake, making it deep enough that people could kayak on it. NASA researchers found that the temporary lake was about 3 feet to less than 1.5 feet deep over the course of about six weeks in February and March 2024.

The lake there today doesn't really compare, locals say.

"It's an attraction, but it's not really a lake," said an employee at the Death Valley Inn, who asked to be identified only as Katt, when reached by phone Thursday. "It's the size of a lake, but it's

[See Lake, A8]

Public lands along border will form militarized zone

Trump's move, new to California, threatens both immigrants and citizens, says ACLU.

By RUBEN VIVES

The Trump administration announced Wednesday that it plans to create a militarized zone along the U.S.-Mexico border in California to support border security operations for three years, the latest in a controversial series of moves aimed at securing the border amid the government's immigration

crackdown.

Secretary of the Interior Doug Burgum said in a written statement that the agency plans to transfer about 760 acres of public land in San Diego and Imperial counties to the Department of the Navy, which will establish a National Defense Area to support border operations.

It's the first time in decades that a large swath of public land has been transferred from the federal government to the military to establish a militarized zone along the U.S.-Mexico border in California.

But the Trump adminis-

tration had taken similar actions elsewhere along the border this year — including in New Mexico, Arizona and Texas — as part of a larger campaign that included sending thousands of troops and military gear to the area.

Border crossings have hit new lows since President Trump took office. In September, Southwest border apprehensions totaled 11,647, compared with 101,790 for the same month in 2024.

Some local officials expressed concern about the move.

San Diego County Board [See Border, A5]



JASON ARMOND Los Angeles Times

PASTOR Connie Larson DeVaughn leads a prayer circle with members of Altadena Baptist Church, which was destroyed in the Eaton fire in January.

COLUMN ONE

Rebuilding their church, along with their lives

Eaton fire tested faith of small Altadena congregation

By Melissa Gomez

The church members gathered around the room, holding hands. They bowed their heads and closed their eyes, waiting for words of comfort.

"We pray for the people who have lost their homes," said Pastor Connie Larson DeVaughn, standing near the center. "The marathon of it, it's harrowing. Harrowing, and stressful."

After a few seconds of silence, the congregation began calling aloud their own prayers.

"Help us to help each other," one woman said.

"Lift burdens here in our congregation, and in our community," one man called out.

For the last 11 months, members of the Altadena Baptist Church have felt the weight of many burdens. On Jan. 8 — the day after the Eaton fire started and rained down embers — flames engulfed their church. The Altadena Children's Center, started by the church, also was incinerated. Twenty congregants lost their homes. Another 20 were displaced.

Since that horrific day, the congregation has bounced around, forced to find different spaces to worship. A few church members have opened their homes to others. Some are rebuilding, while others are staring down the monumental task of doing so. Still others have thrown

[See Church, A6]

Disney plans to invest \$1 billion in OpenAI deal

The studio also will license Mickey Mouse and other characters to startup's Sora tool.

By WENDY LEE AND SAMANTHA MASUNAGA

OpenAI said Thursday it reached a licensing deal with Walt Disney Co. to use more than 200 popular Disney characters including Mickey Mouse, characters from "Frozen" and Yoda from "Star Wars" in OpenAI's text-to-video tool Sora. Disney has also agreed to invest \$1 billion in the San Francisco AI startup.

The deal marks a significant step in Hollywood, as a major studio is partnering with one of the most valuable AI companies in a three-year licensing deal that will bring iconic characters to an AI-powered platform.

Under the deal, users early next year can generate prompts on Sora to create short videos that feature the Disney characters and use ChatGPT Images to create images of the characters in seconds. Some of the Sora-generated videos will be shown on Disney+. The companies said the agreement does not include talent likenesses or voices.

"The rapid advancement of artificial intelligence marks an important moment for our industry, and through this collaboration with OpenAI we will thoughtfully and responsibly extend the reach of our storytelling through generative AI, while respecting and protecting creators and their works," Disney CEO Bob Iger said in a statement.

Artificial intelligence has been a controversial topic in Hollywood, as creative talent have raised concerns about AI companies taking their work or likenesses without their permission and not compensating them enough.

In 2023, actors and writers went on strike to gain more AI protections in their contracts with major studios. There have also been questions raised about what would be the appropriate compensation for intellectual property that could be used to train AI tools.

Disney has had a more contentious relationship with other AI companies. Earlier this year, the company sent a cease-and-desist letter to tech startup Character.AI, alleging that chatbots on the platform were impersonating well-known Disney characters and generated replies that simulated those known [See Disney, A12]

Economy sinking Trump's ratings

His 31% approval is his lowest yet. Poll finds he's slipped on crime and immigration too.

By LINLEY SANDERS AND WILL WEISSERT

WASHINGTON — President Trump's approval numbers on the economy and immigration have fallen substantially since March, according to a new AP-NORC poll, the latest indication that two signature issues that got him elected barely a year ago could be turning into liabilities as his party begins to gear up for the 2026 midterms.

Only 31% of U.S. adults now approve of how Trump is handling the economy, the poll from the Associated Press-NORC Center for Public Affairs Research finds. That is down from 40% in March and marks the lowest economic approval he has registered in an AP-NORC poll in his first or second term. The Republican president also has struggled

to recover from public blowback on other issues, such as his management of the federal government, and has not seen an approval bump even after congressional Democrats in effect capitulated to end a record-long government shutdown last month.

Perhaps most worryingly for Trump, who has become increasingly synonymous with his party, is that he's slipped on issues that were major strengths. Just a few months ago, 53% of Americans approved of Trump's handling of crime, but that has fallen to 43% in the new poll. There has been a similar decline on immigration, from 49% approval in March to 38% now.

The new poll starkly illustrates how Trump has struggled to hold on to political wins since his return to office. Even border security — an issue on which his approval remains relatively high — has declined slightly in recent months.

The good news for Trump is that his overall approval hasn't fallen as [See Poll, A5]

Critics dispute cost of a Hahn Hall retrofit

By ROGER VINCENT

Los Angeles County plunked down \$200 million last year to buy the Gas Company Tower, calculating that moving to the posh downtown address was a steal compared with the \$700 million it might cost to make its old headquarters earthquake-safe.

But the decision to leave the historic Kenneth Hahn Hall of Administration was based on a half-billion-dollar miscalculation, says a group of experts and politicians

trying to save it.

The \$700-million estimate was a massive exaggeration, as it relied on one of the most expensive methods of quake retrofitting, says developer and preservationist Dan Rosenfeld, who is leading the group.

When it presented the estimate for a retrofit, Public Works "didn't just put their thumb on the scale" to show retrofitting was too costly, he said, "they jumped on it with both feet."

The 10-story structure stretches a full city block and [See Hahn Hall, A8]

Senate rejects bid on ACA subsidies

Millions of Americans will see steep increases in their healthcare costs next year. **NATION, A3**

Cougars may get protected status

Wildlife officials say it's long overdue to label the big cats as a threatened species. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

USC to use SoFi after '28 Games

Trojan football probably won't have Coliseum, and Inglewood would be logical site. **SPORTS, B10**

Weather
Mostly sunny; warm.
L.A. Basin: 80/50. **B6**

Markets **A12**
Opinion Voices **A13**

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